MAICON FORWARD

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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

Seen. Believed. Chosen: AI Optimization That Builds Visibility and Credibility

Date & time: Oct. 14, 11:40 AM-12:15 PM
Track: Strategic AI



Wil Reynolds

Founder and CEO, Seer Interactive

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Session Description

We're at a red pill vs. blue pill moment in marketing.

AI has forced every marketer to make a choice: are we willing to sacrifice credibility in order to maximize visibility?

Every tool seems to promise the same thing: more content, faster, with fewer people. And while that approach can work, it has also gone off the rails. More output does not automatically mean more trust. More visibility does not automatically mean more pipeline. And more AI-generated content does not automatically make a brand more useful, authoritative, or chosen.

In this session, Wil Reynolds will share lessons from the failed volume game: what happens when marketing teams focus too much on being seen and not enough on being believed. Reynolds will walk through the real numbers, decisions, and tradeoffs behind his AI Optimization strategy across both sales and marketing.

You'll see exactly what Reynolds uses AI for, what he refuses to use it for, and how he decides the difference. Everything.

Attendees will leave with a practical way to evaluate AI Optimization strategies through the lens of visibility, credibility, and buyer trust—so they can scale what works without eroding the authority their brand depends on.

Key Quote

> *"AI search and Google search are nothing more than proxies for human trust."* **- Wil Reynolds**

Session Summary

Wil Reynolds, founder and CEO of Seer Interactive, challenged marketers to stop treating AI visibility as the finish line. His framework is simple: the job of marketing is to be seen, believed, and chosen, and nobody actually gets paid on being visible in AI. He pointed out that a brand can show up in AI answers and still not be recommended, citing a large vacation rental company that was visible in an AI response but effectively anti-recommended.

Reynolds described a shift from "AI 1.0" to "AI 2.0." In the first version, AI tools leaned on "best" and "top" searches, so competitors who mass-produced self-serving listicles won. Seer refused to play that game and was beaten for 18 months. In version 2.0, query fan-outs increasingly include the names of brands the AI already trusts, and some searches go directly to those brands' own websites. He warned that loophole-driven strategies produce a traffic roller coaster, using the example of Banana Republic outranking Nudie Jeans for ethical jeans by repeating the right words on a page.

On being believed, Reynolds cited a Kevin Indig study showing that while 74% of people pick a vendor from an AI-generated shortlist, 26% re-rank that list based on brands they already recognize and trust. Just as people instantly think of Ritz-Carlton or Four Seasons for luxury hotels, AI has brands hardwired for every industry and looks for "receipts" to back up what a brand says about itself. That means coordinating brand, PR, sales, and paid teams, earning mentions from trusted curators like Search Engine Land, and getting industry thought leaders to share your work. He also urged marketers to study psychology and pre-internet marketing books rather than relying only on AI.

For being chosen, Reynolds shared that Seer's direct traffic converts two and a half times better, and social traffic six times better, than search or AI. Content that humans engage with also creates data he uses to find prospects and recruits. He closed with practical prompts built on sales call transcripts, rank tracking, and traffic

data, such as asking what words or concerns show up in sales calls that are missing from sales materials or the website.

His central message: the job is to win the humans and the AI together, because the AI's brain already has brands hardwired in it the same way people do.

Key Takeaways

- **Visibility isn't the goal.** Being seen in AI answers only matters if buyers then believe you and choose you, and a brand can be visible without being recommended.
- **Skip the loophole strategies.** Self-serving "best" and "top" listicles may have won the first version of AI search, but Reynolds warned they lead to a roller-coaster crash as AI looks harder for trusted brands.
- **Build receipts across teams.** AI looks for evidence from brand, PR, sales, paid, and trusted third parties like Capterra, so winning takes coordination well beyond the SEO team.
- **Earn trusted curators.** Mentions from the publications and thought leaders your industry already trusts signal that your brand is becoming hardwired into both human and AI decision-making.
- **Mine your sales calls.** Prompting AI with sales call transcripts reveals customer concerns missing from your website, sales materials, and tracked prompts.
- **Value human signals.** Reynolds' direct traffic converts two and a half times better and social traffic six times better than search or AI, so content people share is worth more than visibility alone.